

1949–1959

BIRTH OF THE TEENAGER

Up until the late 1940s most young people left school before the age of 16 to start work or join the military. In the 1950s families were better off, and young people stayed at home for longer, but this new generation looked for a way to assert their independence – by dressing differently. Denim companies targeted teens with the new drainpipe jeans, and rock 'n' roll stars such as Eddie Cochran and Elvis Presley fuelled demand. When Marlon Brando wore jeans and a leather jacket in *The Wild One* in 1953, teens found a new fashion uniform in which to rebel. Many youth style tribes originated in the US, including bobby-soxers in poodle skirts, and Beats in bohemian black. But there were also teddy boys, teddy girls, and rockers in the UK; the *Kaminari zoku* (Thunder Tribe) in Japan; and boddies and wiggies in Australia, to name a few.

SILHOUETTE SHAPERS

After the slender silhouette of the 1930s, Christian Dior's New Look of 1947 brought back the bouffant petticoat. Interestingly, what began as a high fashion look was appropriated by teenage girls in the 1950s. Layers of tulle underpinned cinched circle skirts, which were paired with a fitted cardigan, ankle socks, and flat shoes. Dance was the catalyst for the obsession with starched petticoats. As girls danced the jive and jitterbug, petticoats showed off their moves, and also preserved their modesty. The newly invented bustier was equally important in creating an alluring silhouette.

Starched to achieve full shape

Petticoat with bustier

Cardigan essential

Pert bustline sought after

Wide skirt to show off legs while dancing

Stiletto heels are invented, though few teens wear them

Scoop or square neckline

Belted to emphasize waist

Simply cut dress in cotton or nylon

1951

Metallic, pointed-toe pumps

Sweater girl The cardigan, preferably in mohair or angora, was a must-have item. It was often worn buttoned at the back, which emphasized the bust and created the sweater-girl effect made famous by Hollywood sex symbols.

Cotton dance dress For girls in the 1950s the highlight of the social calendar was going to a dance, whether a prom or an informal event held by the school or community. New music styles and dance crazes made these occasions constantly exciting.